FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

When the Indian cricket squad for England was announced in late May, expectations were low. Earlier that month, cricketing greats Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma had hung up their boots within five days of each other. The selectors felt it was a good time to experiment. It would be a new-look team, an untested combination under debutant skipper Shubman Gill. Tall and willowy, he was already an icon of swashbuckling strokeplay. Now, at age 25, he was being tested as captain in a prestigious away series. It was baptism by fire for both him and the New Gen XI he was leading. In the batting line-up around him, K.L. Rahul had class and copybook poise, young Yashasvi Jaiswal was a model of southpaw elegance, and vice-captain Rishabh Pant could stir up a storm. But they would need to stand on their own, not merely be flamboyant add-on flavours. On the bowling side, India had the world-class Jasprit Bumrah, but he was injury-prone. That left only a second line of defence in Mohammed Siraj, Akash Deep and Prasidh Krishna. So, when the series began, no one foresaw that Indian cricket was heading for a historic rite of passage.

Like India, the England team, too, was 'under construction', so to speak. Joe Root, who became the second most prolific run-scorer in Test history in this series, was the only elder statesman. Headed by the highly talented Ben Stokes, it was essentially a team of spunky rookies who thrived on the aggression of 'Bazball'—a spiffy name for T20-style tactics deployed in Test cricket. As it happened, the battle of the colts turned out to be what Bollywood calls a full *paisa vasool* entertainer. There was heartbreak and tears, plenty of twists and thrills, arcs of redemption and scenes of delirious joy. There were innings of magnificent beauty and true grit with bat and spells of magic with ball. It was as vital and thrilling an advertisement for Test cricket as any we have seen in the age of T-20 cricket. A total of 7,000+ runs were scored across the five Tests, the second highest aggregate in history. India scored 3,807 runs in all, the most by any team in a five-match series. Three Indian batters—Gill, Rahul and Ravindra Jadeja—crossed 500 runs, a first in India-England Tests. A total of 21 centuries came about, the most in any India-England series. Again, India had 12, England 9.

This glut of runs came because the home team had prepared a series of flat tracks, shorn of grass. Often, there was no mystery of the moving ball to solve, a feature of cricket in England. Yet, Indian pacers extracted more life out of those unhelpful belters than their English counterparts. A lion-hearted Siraj bowled an incredible 185.3 overs, with nip, swing, cut and some unseen laser guidance system that kept him on the stumps. Topping with 23 wickets, Siraj deservedly starred in the heart-stopping climax at The Oval, with Krishna getting his share of scalps. Akash Deep's 10-wicket haul helped India to its first win, at Edgbaston. Jadeja and Washington Sundar are in reality both batting all-rounders, and got crucial centuries at crunch moments, but their tight, disciplined spin gave cover fire. Together, incredibly, this bowling collective filled in for the in-and-out maestro, Bumrah, not letting the team feel the weight of his absence when he couldn't take the field, as in the final match.

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Both teams had a higher-than-usual share of newbies on apprenticeship, so the cricket may have been sometimes short of the highest calibre. But the competitiveness was so intense, and the spirits so unflagging, that it produced the most engrossing Test cricket. Even though the series ended with the honours shared at 2-2, the heart-stopping narrative lurched towards that happy ending in such a way that it felt like a win for India. That's why former India captain Sunil Gavaskar called India's six-run triumph in the final match at The Oval "the greatest of wins in Indian cricket history".

Above all, there was Gill himself. His all-time record of 754 runs became emblematic of the summits that were being scaled. It's also the way he made them, digging deep into hitherto untapped reservoirs of patience, crafting his runs around time. He was thinking not only as a batsman, but as a captain, the two faculties fused in him like mature wine. Mirroring him was an entire team that now appears like a full starburst. In each of its new components, one saw cricketing skills adapt and grow in stature as well as depth, while passing the test of temperament. India's generation next is unfazed by pressure and expectations, and ready for a challenge. There's depth in batting and an abundance of fast bowlers. And there's the never-say-die spirit, the gamesmanship and the ability to hold one's ground.

In this week's cover story, Nikhil Naz, Consulting Editor, Sports, India Today TV, who was following the series, honours this epoch-turning moment where, under rainy English skies, grit and character glowed in the furnace, turning our boys to men.

(Aroon Purie)